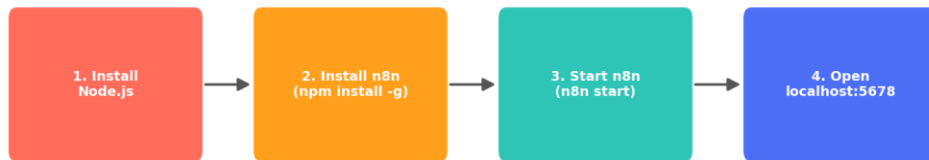


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## HOW-TO GUIDE

# How to Install n8n Locally

*A beginner-friendly, step-by-step guide to running n8n on your own computer — plus licensing, Docker, and Local vs Cloud explained.*



Prepared for the n8n Learning Community

## Prerequisites

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Before installing n8n, you need Node.js installed — n8n runs on it, and npm (Node's package manager) comes bundled with it.

### Minimum system requirements

- Windows 10/11 (64-bit), macOS, or Linux
- At least 4 GB RAM (8 GB recommended)
- A few hundred MB of free storage

## Step-by-Step Installation

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### Step 1 — Install Node.js

1. Go to [nodejs.org](https://nodejs.org)
2. Click the LTS download button on the homepage (auto-detects your OS)
3. Run the downloaded installer and click through with default options
4. Restart your computer if prompted

Verify it worked — open a terminal and run:

```
node -v
npm -v
```

**Note:** If you see a warning about "Tools for Native Modules" or a Visual Studio installer failing, you can safely ignore it — it's an optional add-on.

### Step 2 — Install n8n

In the same terminal, run:

```
npm install n8n -g
```

This downloads and installs n8n globally. It may take a few minutes and show a lot of scrolling text — that's normal.

### Step 3 — Start n8n

```
n8n start
```

Wait for the terminal to show:

```
Editor is now accessible via:  
http://localhost:5678
```

## Step 4 — Open n8n in Your Browser

Go to <http://localhost:5678>. You'll be asked to create a local admin account (your own email + password — this stays on your machine).

You'll then see a few optional setup popups — all safe to skip for now and configure later in Settings:

- Free license key — unlocks extra features (advanced debugging, folders, execution search)
- Connect an AI model — only needed for the built-in n8n Assistant
- Code sandbox — only needed if AI Agents need to execute code (requires Docker)

## Starting n8n Each Time

n8n does not run automatically in the background. Every time you restart your computer or close the terminal, you'll need to run n8n start again.

**Tip — create a one-click shortcut:**

1. Right-click your Desktop → New → Text Document
2. Open it and type exactly: n8n start
3. File → Save As → set "Save as type" to All Files → name it start-n8n.bat
4. Double-click that file anytime to launch n8n

**Note:** The first time you run n8n start, Windows may show a Firewall popup — click "Allow access". This is normal.

## Why Docker Was Skipped

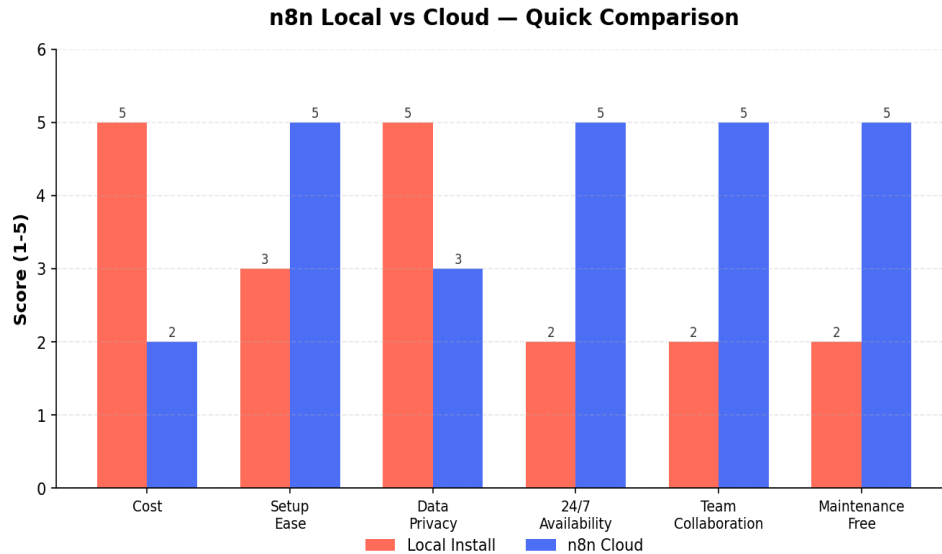
Docker is only needed for one optional feature: the n8n Sandbox, which lets the AI Assistant/Agents execute code and work with files in isolation. For basic workflow building — connecting apps, automations, using AI models via API keys — Docker is not required at all.

### Reasons to skip it for a simple setup

- Adds extra setup (Docker Desktop, WSL2, sometimes BIOS virtualization settings)
- Uses more RAM, which matters on lower-spec laptops (8 GB RAM)
- Not needed unless using AI Agents that execute code or work with local files
- The plain npm installation is faster to get running and enough for learning n8n

**Note:** Docker is free for personal use and can be added later anytime, without reinstalling n8n.

## Local vs. Cloud — Quick Comparison



| Aspect       | Local Install                   | n8n Cloud                      |
|--------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Cost         | Free, forever                   | Paid subscription (free trial) |
| Setup effort | Install Node.js + n8n yourself  | Ready instantly, no setup      |
| Data privacy | Everything stays on your device | Data stored on n8n's servers   |
| Availability | Only while your laptop is on    | Always online, 24/7            |
| Team sharing | Harder — local to your device   | Easy — shared team access      |
| Maintenance  | You handle updates & backups    | Handled by n8n                 |
| Best for     | Learning, testing, personal use | Production, teams, 24/7 jobs   |

**In short:** Local is great for learning, testing, and keeping full control of your data — but it only runs when your laptop is on. Cloud is better for 24/7 automations or team collaboration, at the cost of a subscription.

## Is Local Install Allowed? Does n8n Lose Money?

Yes, running n8n locally is completely legitimate — n8n actually encourages it.

- n8n is "fair-code" licensed under the Sustainable Use License, which explicitly allows free self-hosting for personal, internal, and most business use
- n8n's revenue comes from n8n Cloud (paid hosting) and Enterprise plans (SSO, permissions, support) — not from restricting self-hosting
- Free local users help n8n's business: they grow the community and often upgrade to Cloud/Enterprise later
- The only real restriction: you can't resell n8n itself as your own competing hosted service

## Using Local n8n for Paid Client Work

Building automations for paying clients is explicitly allowed under n8n's license — their own docs list consulting and workflow-building as a permitted use case.

| ✓ Allowed (free, no extra license)              | ✗ Requires a paid commercial agreement         |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Using n8n for your own internal automation      | White-labeling n8n and selling it to customers |
| Building & selling workflows for paying clients | Hosting n8n and charging people to access it   |
| Using n8n as the backend for your own product   | Making n8n itself the product you're selling   |
| Consulting / freelance automation services      |                                                |

**The simple test:** if a customer is paying for your service or product (and n8n is just the tool), you're fine. If they're paying essentially for access to n8n itself, that needs a commercial license.

## Practical Notes for Production / Client Work

- A local laptop install is great for building & testing client workflows
- Not ideal for running a client's live automation long-term — if your laptop is off, their automation stops
- For production delivery: hand over the workflow file for them to run on their own instance, or host it yourself on an always-on server as part of your service
- Local install remains perfect for development, testing, and learning before deploying elsewhere